Tata Trusts: The Betterment of Society

The Tata Trusts were created and exist for the sole purpose of undertaking philanthropic activities. The University of San Diego, which is a beneficiary of the Trusts and houses the Tata Hall, describes the Tata Trusts as ‘a philanthropic organization that plays a pioneering role in transforming charity work into lasting societal change focused on improving education, health, employment, nutrition and water security by pursuing grant-making, direct implementation of change and creating co-partnership strategies’.

Even prior to the establishment of the Trusts, the Tatas had been undertaking activities for the betterment of the society and it has now been over 130 years (1892–2022). They assisted governments and non-government organizations, intervened in areas of education, health, arts, crafts and culture especially at the rural level, and worked to ameliorate poverty, enhance the income of the marginalized and benefit the society.

Though it is not an aspect that is highlighted, there is an underlying religious edict that has persuaded the creation of the Tata Trusts. It is embedded in the sanctification of philanthropy by Zoroastrianism. What has aided the process is the encouragement of the creation of wealth by the religion under certain conditions.

The religious teachings of Parsis demand that wealth be earned righteously and employed for noble purposes. As a logical corollary, the faithful believe that they should hold wealth as trustees of the society. Extending this noble idea, the Parsi religious texts exhort followers to secure happiness by making others happy. Charity, therefore, is a sacrosanct religious canon. These have made Parsis so famous for their contribution to the welfare of society that Mahatma Gandhi commented, ‘In numbers, Parsis are beneath contempt, but in contribution beyond compare’.

The Tata Trusts were created by successive Tata leaders who left the lion’s share of their wealth for charity. They were motivated by the vision of the founding father, Jamsetji Nusserwanji Tata, who placed service to the